



THE VOICE EXPRESS

The Truth Takes Time.

THE VOICE EXPRESS GAZETTE

MEDIA

Editor's Desk: Then They Came for the News

An editorial invoking Martin Niemöller's 'First They Came' as an allegory for the creeping suppression of the Indian press — and a statement on what The Voice Express is choosing to stand for in calling itself a publication, not just a student blog.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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ABOUT

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time.

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“

First they came for the socialists, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a socialist. Then they came for the trade unionists, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a trade unionist. Then they came for the Jews, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a Jew. Then they came for me—and there was no one left to speak for me.

MARTIN NIEMÖLLER, 1946.

If you didn't get that joke, then you perhaps haven't heard of Martin Niemöller, a Nazi Sympathizer turned Holocaust victim, a particular speech of whose for many a German after the war transformed the image of the Nazi party from an overambitious & unfortunate political organization to the cartoonishly evil & genocidal monsters we know & love to condemn them as today. You see, good Christian Martin here wrote a poem (yes, a speech, really, but they called it a confessional poem, & for good reason so we'll leave it at that), & it went something like this:

***First they came for the socialists, and I did not speak out—
Because I was not a socialist. Then they came for the trade
unionists, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a
trade unionist. Then they came for the Jews, and I did not
speak out— Because I was not a Jew. Then they came for me
—and there was no one left to speak for me.***

MARTIN NIEMÖLLER, 1946.

If you were here two months ago, you would remember a time when we hadn't the confidence to call this little publication here even a news website, let alone a good, or – God forbid – honest one. Just college students trying to say what we think is worth saying, we called it instead. “Whatever literature you do find here, it isn't yet news, not quite, but it does possess the beginnings of it,” we said.

“And it is in those beginnings that we hope to someday find the becoming's of it, as well. Regardless of whether or not we'll be any more qualified to declare them so then than we are now, & regardless of whether or not either of us has any business trying to find out. We might not, on both counts. But then again, what is youth if not fighting a war you did not start.”

As of 25th November 2023 (remember, remember), they've come first for the professors, & we've done nothing, because we are not professors. (Edit: As of March 2024, they've come for the activists, they've come for the farmers, they've come for the Muslims, they've come for the students, & they've come for the politicians, & we are much closer to an answer than we were five months ago, of exactly where in the line it is that our number falls.) So, it's safe to say, that as of November 2023, our youth means nothing. And it's about damn time then, that we start that war.

Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>^[1]) back in September 2023.

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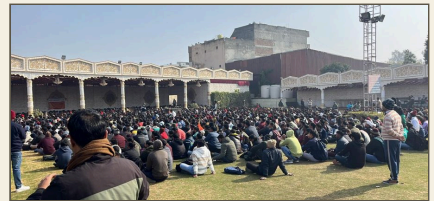
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